Week 10: Poetic Metaphor

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Biblical poets return to the same handful of images again and again — tonight we'll look at a few of them and what they're doing.

1. What's a metaphor or turn of phrase you use often without really thinking about it — "I'm drowning in work," "that doesn't hold water," "she lit up the room"? Where do you think it originally came from?

2. **Read Isaiah 17:12-14.** What happens to these roaring, rumbling nations by the end of the passage (vv. 13-14)? Nations that "rage" and "roar" like a stormy sea is a common image throughout Scripture for overwhelming danger and chaos. When have you felt like you were being swept under by "roaring waters" — whether that was circumstances, anxiety, or conflict in your life?

3. **Read Joel 2:1-3.** What does the text say this coming army looks like, and what does it say the land looks like before and after it passes through (vv. 2-3)? Why might picturing a crisis as the undoing of Eden hit differently than a plain description of an approaching army?

4. **Read Hosea 2:18-19.** What two things does God promise in these verses, and what words does he use to describe his relationship with his people (vv. 18-19)? Why do you think safety from danger and marital faithfulness are pictured together here as one single vision of peace (shalom)?

5. **Read Psalm 92:11-15.** What does the psalm say the righteous will still be doing, even in old age (vv. 13-14)? What does picturing spiritual health as something slow-growing and deeply rooted, rather than instant, suggest about how you think about your own growth?

6. **Read Revelation 21:1-3.** What does John see and hear in this vision, and what does the voice from the throne announce (vv. 1-3)? How do these two threads we've traced tonight, chaotic water and marriage, come together in this final picture of restoration?

7. These same images — stormy seas as danger, gardens as safety, wild animals as threat or peace, marriage as faithfulness — show up again and again in books written hundreds of years apart. What does that kind of consistency tell you about how unified the Bible's imagination really is?

8. A good metaphor reveals some things about its subject and conceals others — no image is a perfect one-to-one description. Does it bother you, or comfort you, that so much of what Scripture says about God comes to us through metaphor rather than flat, literal statement?

9. Which image from tonight — raging water, an invaded garden, a wild animal at peace, a flourishing tree, or a bride prepared for her wedding — best captures where you feel you are with God right now? Why that one?